

plurality. Between meetings, I sat and drank rum and cokes while my colleagues read Sidney Sheldon novels on plastic lounge chairs. When asked about their holdings, most were tight-lipped, though several admitted to owning tax-free municipals. I told everybody I met I owned Angstrom.

Whenever possible, we sidled up to the financial celebrities among us, treating them at first with simple respect and later with giddy adoration as the Dow industrials broke through 1558 for the first time. I was excited to see several forecasters and publishers of newsletters whose names and faces I recognized from television. Thanks to the televised financial programs, these once-obscure advisors now reached millions of average investors and sometimes moved entire markets with their predictions. Not long ago, a sell signal from Joseph Granville caused the Dow averages to fall as many points as they had on Black Thursday, 1929, the day of the so-called Crash.

One of my former brokers became a disciple of Mr. Granville's just as Mr. Granville started getting everything wrong, so I was just as glad Mr. Granville wasn't here. Among those who did show up there was Bert "Worry-free Investing" Dohmen-Ramirez, Stan "Don't Be Dow Crazy" Weinstein, Norm "Contrary Opinion" Fosback, Charles "Nobody Knows Where the Market Is Headed" Allmon, Mark "Buy at the Sound of Cannons" Spangler, Robert "10 Percent Correction" Nicholson, Ray "Watch the Falling Dollar" Dalio, Robert "Life Is But a Wave" Prechter, Robert "Elf" Nurock, and Al "Undervalued" Frank. Also, I. W. "Tubby" Burnham, the head of Drexel Burnham Lambert, showed up at lunch to tell everybody it would be a great year for stocks.

Between our meetings and at nightly cocktail parties, we were well supplied with free canapés and pigs-in-the-blanket. After filling my plate, I lurked behind the celebrities and rotated my ears in their direction, to better pick up what they were saying, especially to each other. I overheard Bert Dohmen-Ramirez predict a 2,000 Dow in the coming year; Charles Allmon and Robert Nicholson were worried; Stan Weinstein saw a "choppy near-term"; Norm Fosback was bullish. Ray Dalio told somebody to "watch the cap utilization rate"—whatever that was—and Mark Spangler